Data Center Traffic Types (2026 Estimate)

Conversation excerpt, Thursday, October 15, 2026

Prompt

create a table of data center traffic types, i.e., AI, Streaming, ... Estimate the number of types sent. state the date of this information

Reply

No current public source breaks down all data center traffic by type, so the table below is an estimate built from the most recent published anchors. It covers traffic leaving data centers for users (the internet traffic people consume) for 2026. Traffic inside data centers is covered separately below the table.

Estimated 2026 internet traffic by type (data center -> users)

Total assumed: about 600 exabytes (EB) per month, based on an IBISWorld forecast of 602.1 EB/month for 2026.

Traffic type	Est. share of bytes	Est. volume (EB/month)	Main anchor
Video streaming (on-demand, social video, live, IPTV)	~65%	~390	Sandvine, 1H 2022 data
Web browsing and general HTTP (incl. bot/crawler fetches)	~10%	~60	Sandvine 2018 split, adjusted down as video grew
Gaming (game downloads, updates, cloud gaming, play)	~6%	~36	Sandvine 2018, adjusted
Social (non-video), messaging, video conferencing	~6%	~36	Sandvine 2018, adjusted
Cloud storage, backups, software updates, file sharing	~6%	~36	Estimate
Marketplace / e-commerce	~3%	~18	Sandvine 2018, adjusted
VPN, other, unclassified	~3%	~18	Estimate
AI inference (chatbots, agents, LLM APIs)	<1%	<6	Cisco, May 2026
Total	**100%**	**~600**	

What the anchors say

- **Video.** Sandvine's 2023 report found that video made up 65.93% of total internet volume in the first half of 2022. This is the most recent category breakdown found. Sandvine, now renamed AppLogic Networks, released a 2025 edition, but its category figures did not come up in the search.
- **Smaller categories.** The 2018 Sandvine report gave video 57.69%, general web browsing 17.01%, gaming 7.78%, social 5.1%, and marketplace 4.61%. Video's share has grown since then, so the other categories were scaled down to fit.
- **AI inference.** Cisco's 2026 WAN report says AI inference traffic is still negligible next to categories like video streaming, but it is growing very fast. Token consumption is up nearly 10x year over year, and some

providers measured about 4x growth in eight months. Cisco projects AI inference will reach 25% of total network traffic by 2035.

- **Bots vs. bytes.** Bots now generate most HTML page requests, but page fetches are tiny next to video streams. That is why AI and bot traffic is large by request count but small by bytes.

Inside data centers (east-west traffic)

This traffic is not in the table. Model training moves terabytes between servers inside data centers, but that traffic does not cross the WAN, apart from large data transfers for training. By that measure AI training is likely the largest single source of internal traffic, but no one publishes a byte-level breakdown. The workload figures available are about compute rather than network bytes. AI was roughly a quarter of total data center workloads in 2025, mostly training. Deloitte expects inference to be about two-thirds of AI compute in 2026.

Dates

- Total volume: 2026 forecast (IBISWorld).
- Video share: 1H 2022 data, published in Sandvine's 2023 report.
- Other category splits: 2018 Sandvine report.
- AI inference: Cisco report dated May 2026.
- Shares and volumes: estimates as of October 15, 2026.

The video figure is reasonably solid. The minor categories carry about +/-3 percentage points of uncertainty each.

Sources

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